

Chapter – 5: The Rise of Empires

There cannot be a country without people and there is no kingdom without a country. – Kautilya in Arthaśhāstra

- Bhavisha, Dhruv – use device – Itihasa – time machine – visit Pataliputra
- Landing on outskirts – obs. – girl talking to person – strange clothes
- Person leaves – girl talks with them – they ask name
- She introduces herself – Ira – daughter of Kanhadadas – ironsmith – welcomes them
- They introduce themselves – she asks them – keep quiet
- She points out – marching soldiers – battle – neighbour kingdom
- She explains – their king – avoids war – BUT – also protects people
- She also informs them – her father – provided many swords – her uncle – soldier
- Grp. – obs. soldiers – crossing drawbridge – children cross the same bridge
- Bhavisha – very curious – bridge, river
- Ira explains – bridge protects city – lifted in case of danger – also – not river – BUT – moat – protects fortification
- She points out – hills, forests – explains – provides – timber, herbs, other resources – also – elephants – captured there – trained for army
- Dhruv – curious – opening in the hills
- Ira explains – cave – carved for monks – wishes to visit
- Grp. – move through city – obs. splendour
- Ira – points out – market – traders – distant lands
- She insists – visit market – explains – their king – welcomes travelers – all over
- Silk – China – spices, gems – South – fine clothes – diff. regions
- Dhruv – curious – grp. of people – streets
- Ira explains – those people – street acrobats – build human pyramids – sing, dance – act plays – entertain people
- Sometimes – perform – for king
- Bhavisha – praises king – curious – what area – king rules
- Ira explains – he rules – vast land – authority – many villages, towns, kingdoms
- Her uncle told her – 2 months – horseback ride – reach borders
- Ira informed – this kind of rule – bigger than kingdom – called empire

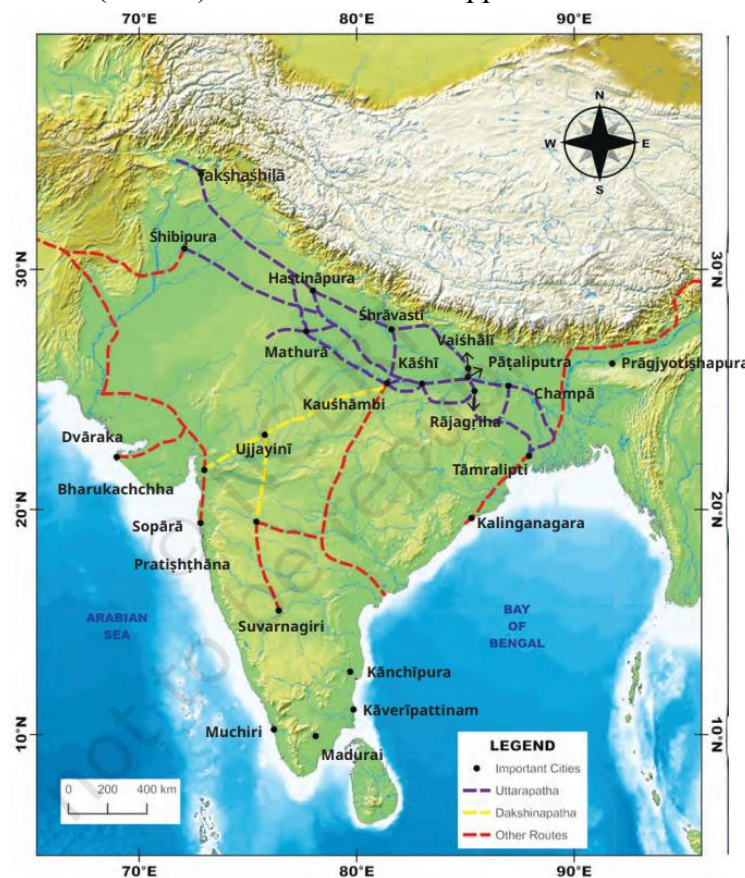
What is an Empire?

- Empire – Latin – imperium – meaning – super power
- Empire – collection – smaller kingdoms – power ruler – exert power
- Smaller kingdoms – own rulers – BUT – they all – tributaries to emperor – ruled from capital – major centre – economic, administrative power
- Ancient Sanskrit text – common word for emperor –
 - *Samraj* – lord of all
 - *Adhiraja* – overlord
 - *Rajadhiraja* – king of kings
- Indian history – full of empires – rose, expanded, lasted, declined, disappeared
- Last empire – ruling subcontinent – last century
- Features of an empire – emperor exerts central authority –

- Maintains army – keep states under control – expand or protect empire
- Design, maintain administration – manage territories – collect taxes – maintain law
- Makes law – issue currency, weights, measures – regulate trade
- Control, regulate access – resources – mines, forest, agriculture, etc
- Encourage – art, literature, religion, learning
- Maintain comm. n/w – other infra. – administration, trade, people's welfare
- For – tribute, loyalty – emperors – allowed local kings – rules their areas

Trade, trade routes and guilds

- Military campaigns – distant lands – not that simple
- Maintaining army – very costly –
 - Soldiers – fed, clothed, weapons, paid
 - Elephants, horses – cared for
 - Roads, ships – built
- Economic activity – production, trade – main aspect – maintaining empire – ensuring quality of life
- Control – **trade routes** – entire territory and beyond – very imp.
- Goods – grow – quantity, variety – more trade – more income (producers) – more tax collection (rulers)
- Ancient India – traded goods – plenty of evidence – literature, archaeological excavations – textiles, spices, agriculture, animals
- This trade – not limited to India – many goods – travelled – distant lands
- Traders – soon understood – benefits – joining forces – **guilds** – *shrenis*
- Guilds – powerful associations – traders, craftsmen, money lenders, etc.
- Evidence – guild – head (elected) and executives – supposed to have – ethical qualities



- 2 things – guilds – remarkable institution –
 - Brought people together – became collaborators – realized – sharing – resources, info. – everyone's benefit

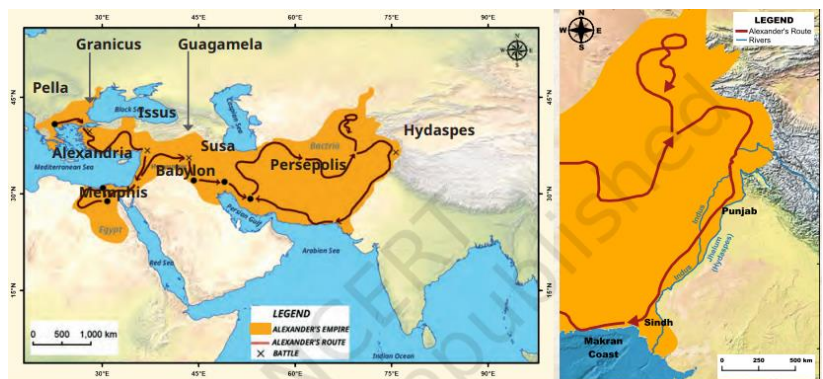
- Guilds – autonomy – internal rules – king – does not interfere
- Guilds – spread over – large parts – centuries
- They ceased to exist – spirit continued – influence India's trade
- Guilds, village units – example – **self-organizing abilities** – Indian society
- Enlightened ruler – let people organise – refrain from interfering

The Rise of Magadha

- Period – 6th-4th cent. BCE – profound change – north India
- Earlier – 16 *mahajanapadas* – large kingdoms – assembly sys.
- Magadha – very imp. – set stage – fusion – many kingdoms – India's 1st empire
- Powerful early kings – Ajatashatru – imp. role – establish Magadha – dominant centre
- Magadha – located – resource-rich Ganga plains – fertile land – abundant forest – timber, elephants
- Use of iron – transform other tech. – agriculture, welfare
- Iron ore, other minerals – nearby hills – very imp. – expansion
- Iron ploughs – increased agriculture – iron weapons – lighter, sharper – strengthened army
- Surplus food grains – allowed people – focus – arts, crafts – in demand – inside, outside borders
- Ganga, Son – geographical adv. – trade – used for transport – boosted income – Magadha's rise
- 5th cent. BCE – Mahapadma Nanda – very imp. – founded – Nanda dynasty
- Successfully unified – smaller kingdoms – extended empire – eastern, northern India
- Economy thrived – issued coins – demonstrate economic power – Greek accounts – Nanda dynasty – maintain large army
- Various accounts – Nanda dynasty – last ruler – Dhana Nanda – very rich – BUT – unpopular – oppressed, exploited his people
- This led way – Nanda empire – conquered, absorbed into – Maurya empire

The Arrival of the Greeks

- Events – happening in Magadha – eastern part
- Northwestern part – smaller kingdoms – ancient route – connecting Mediterranean
- Greek accounts – Pauravas – led by king Porus



- 334 – 331 BCE –
 - Alexander – young Greek king – Macedonia – campaign – Persian empire – avenge earlier invasions
 - Conquered – Persian Empire – influence spread – empire – spread over – 3 continents
- 327 – 325 BCE –
 - Alexander – eager to rich – end of world – pushed east – came to India – defeated Porus – fierce resistance – local tribes – massacred – several cities
 - Greek records – mention – women fought side by side with men
 - Alexander – seriously wounded – soldiers – lost will – returned from India – BUT – coastal route – Iran's harsh desert conditions – result – heavy losses – troops

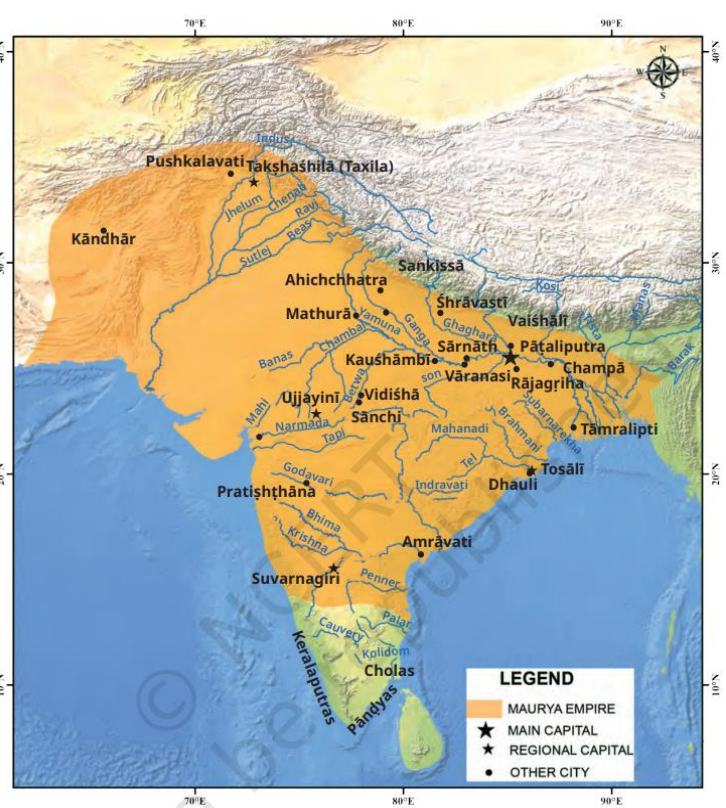
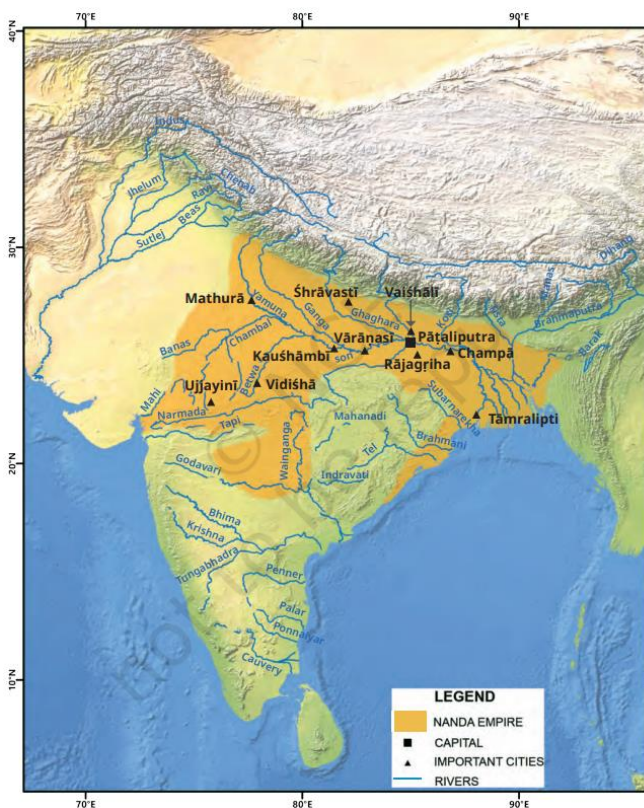
- 324 – 323 BCE –
 - Back in Persia – Alexander – political turmoil
 - He fell ill – died in Babylon – age 32 – empire divided – between generals – created own kingdoms

The Mighty Mauryas

- Return to Magadha – decline of Nanda Dynasty
- 321 BCE – Alexander left – new dynasty, empire – Maurya Empire – founded by – Chandragupta Maurya
- Quickly absorbed – Nanda empire – expand beyond
- Many accounts – Chandragupta – managed all this – able mentor – Kautilya – knowledge – politics, governance, economics – create empire – greatest in history

The story of Kautilya

- Buddhists texts – Kautilya – sometimes – Chanakya or Vishnugupta – teacher – world-renowned Takshashila University
- His tale – starts – court of Dhana Nanda – very unpopular
- Obs. this – Kautilya advised Dhana Nanda – change his attitude
- Dhana Nanda – insulted him – threw him out – Kautilya vowed – end – evil Nanda rule



The rise of Chandragupta Maurya

- Many stories – origin, adventures – Chandragupta Maurya – common theme – overthrow Nanda – took control – Magadha – establish his rule – Pataliputra as capital
- Magadha – adv. – geography, economic sys., flourishing trade – combined with – advice – Kautilya – helped Chandragupta – expand empire
- Defeated Greek satraps – left behind – northwest – integrated the region – empire – northern plains to Deccan plateau

- Chandragupta – defeated Greeks – maintain diplomatic relation – hosted – Greek historian – Megasthenes – his court
- Megasthenes – wrote in his book – *Indika* – 1st written account – lost except – some excerpts – quoted later – Greek scholars

Kautilya's concept of a kingdom

- Kautilya – clear vision – kingdom (*rajya*) – established, managed, consolidated
- His famous work – *Arthashastra* – listed directives – many areas – defence, economics, administration, justice, urban planning, agriculture, people's welfare
- Most imp. political concept – *saptanga* – seven parts – constitute kingdom
- According to Kautilya – *saptanga* – together – makes kingdom – settled, well-protected, prosperous
- Emphasis – imp. of law and order – strong administration – necessary
- Also detailed – many laws for corruption – specified punishments for act. against wellbeing
- Kautilya – central philosophy – in tune with Indian values – king – may be powerful – BUT – people's interest – 1st place

Kautilya's Saptanga

- King (*swami*)
- Grp. of councilors, ministers, high officials (*amatya*)
- Fortified towns, cities (*durga*)
- Forces of defence, law, order (*danda*)
- Territory of state, population of state (*janapada*)
- Treasury, wealth of kingdom (*kosha*)
- The allies (*mitra*)

The King Who Chose Peace

- Another king – Maurya dynasty – Ashoka (268 – 232 BCE) – Chandragupta's grandson – credited – major achievements
- Beginning of reign – very ambitious – inherited vast empire – further expanded – cover entire subcontinent – incl. – Bangladesh, Pakistan, parts of Afghanistan – BUT – not southern India
- One encounter – changed his life
- Once – marched on Kalinga (Odisha) – waged – ferocious war
- Enormous amt. – death and destruction – Ashoka – gave up violence – adopted peace, non-violence – Buddhist teachings
- Embracing Buddhist teachings – Ashoka sent emissaries – Sri Lanka,



Thailand, Central Asia – spread – message of Buddha

- Historians – called Ashoka – great communicator – issued edicts – many parts of empire – engraved rocks, pillars – message for people – follow dharma
- Most edicts – Prakrit – popular lang. – many parts of India – Brahmi script
- His edicts – Ashoka called himself – Devanampiya Piyadasi – 1st word – Beloved of the Gods – 2nd word – one who regards others with kindness
- Lang. of edicts – make it clear – Ashoka – interested – depict himself – benevolent, compassionate ruler
- Some southern kingdoms – not part – Mauryan empire – Ashoka supported – wellbeing
- He claimed – medical care – people, animals – even beyond kingdom – prohibited hunting, cruelty
- He established – rest houses, wells – regular intervals – main roads – planted fruit, shade trees
- Also encouraged – all sects – accept each other's best teachings – study them
- Ashoka – paid attention – welfare – his people
- Maurya's empire – continued – half cent. – after Ashoka's death
- His successors – cannot hold empire – many smaller kingdoms – broke off
- 185 BCE – India – started another phase – Bhavisha, Dhruv – join us – this journey – next chapter

Life in the Mauryan Empire

- Cities – Pataliputra – centres – governance, commerce – palaces, public buildings, planned streets
- Organized tax sys. – brisk trade – treasury strong – empire – grows, prospers
- Officials, merchants, artisans – play key role – city life
- Megasthenes' accounts – shade light – society of that time
- Substantial proportion – population – agriculture – imp. src. – revenue of empire
- 2 crops – 1 yr. – rain – summer, winter – ensured – famines – rare – people – ample food
- Granaries – well stocked – any eventualities – war raged nearby – farmers were protected – agriculture not disturbed
- Blacksmiths, potters, other artisans – lived in cities – well-planned – include signage
- Comm. – couriers – carried messages – place to place
- Houses – made of wood – upto 2 storeys – streets – vessels of water – regular intervals – for fire
- Later accounts – cotton dresses – lower garment – reached below knee – upper garment – threw over shoulders
- Side fig. – many messages – beauty, perfection, fine example – Mauryan art
- This capital (top portion) – part of pillar – Ashoka – got erected – Sarnath – Buddha – 1st teachings
- 4 lions – symbolize royal power – ring below – 4 powerful animals – elephant, bull, horse, lion – also *Dharmachakra* – wheel of dharma – symbolize Buddha's teachings
- Adjoining fig. – familiar – chosen – India's national emblem – added Sanskrit motto – *Satyameva Jayate* – truth alone triumphs
- This motto – origin – Mundaka Upanishad – *Satyameva Jayate Nanritam* – truth alone triumphs, not falsehood
- *Dharmachakra* – centre – Indian national flag



सत्यमेव जयते

Some Contributions of Mauryas

Life and people

- Dance styles – hairstyles – jewellery
- Terracotta figurines – female deity – horse – *saptamatrikas* – seven mothers

Art and architecture

- Sanchi stupa – fine example – Indian architecture – Ashoka – constructed many such structures
- Rock sculpture – life-size elephant – Dhauli (Odisha) – symbolizes Buddha – intelligent, powerful, patient, calm – edict of Ashoka – engraved nearby

The Fragile Nature of Empires

- Higher grades – learn – past mighty empires – elsewhere – Roman, Persian, Ottoman, Spanish, Russian, British
- All of them – long gone – BUT – historians – keep debating – cause of decline
- On of the reasons – temptation – some parts – become independent
- Ex. – military campaigns, times of drought – emperor – more resources – local rulers – burdened – increasing demands
- Powerful emperor – followed by weak ruler – local chieftains – take chance – become independent
- Larger empire – more difficult – hold together – Alexander experienced – far-off territories – 1st to split
- Economic crisis – caused by natural calamities – shake empire
- Empires – paradox –
 - One hand – political unity – reduce warfare – greater prosperity
 - Other hand – all empire – established through war – maintained existence – force, repression – make them fragile